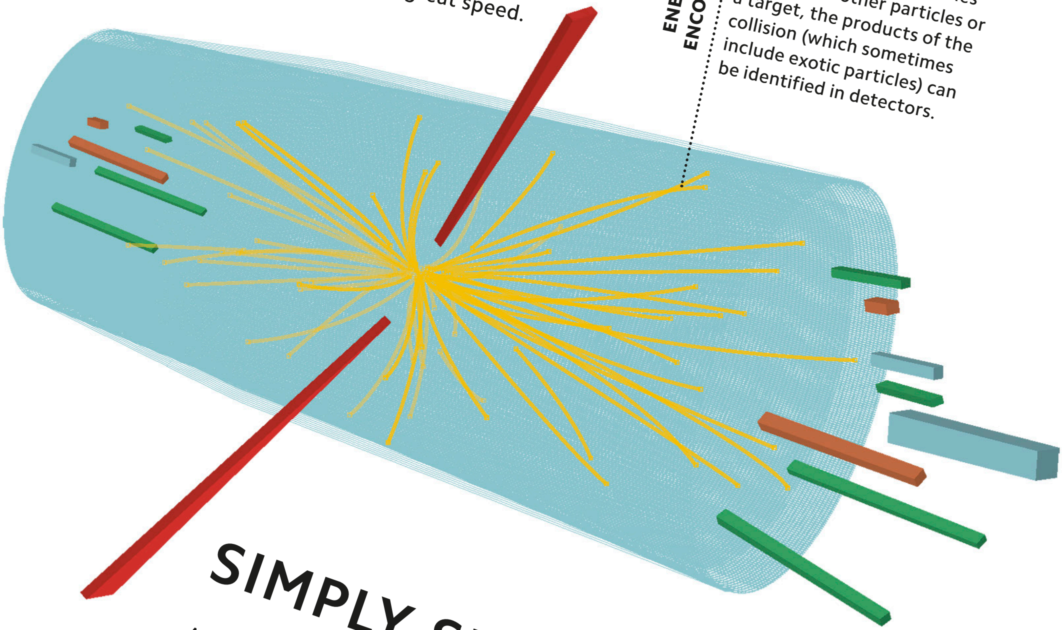

SIMPLY SMASHING

A particle accelerator propels particles to extreme speeds and energies, allowing physicists to probe the smallest objects in nature. Modern particle accelerators use changing electromagnetic fields to accelerate and guide charged particles to almost light speed, and smash them into targets. Smashing particles together causes them to break apart, fuse, and—at extreme energies—create the exotic matter that briefly existed in the instant after the Big Bang.